Signé par Em

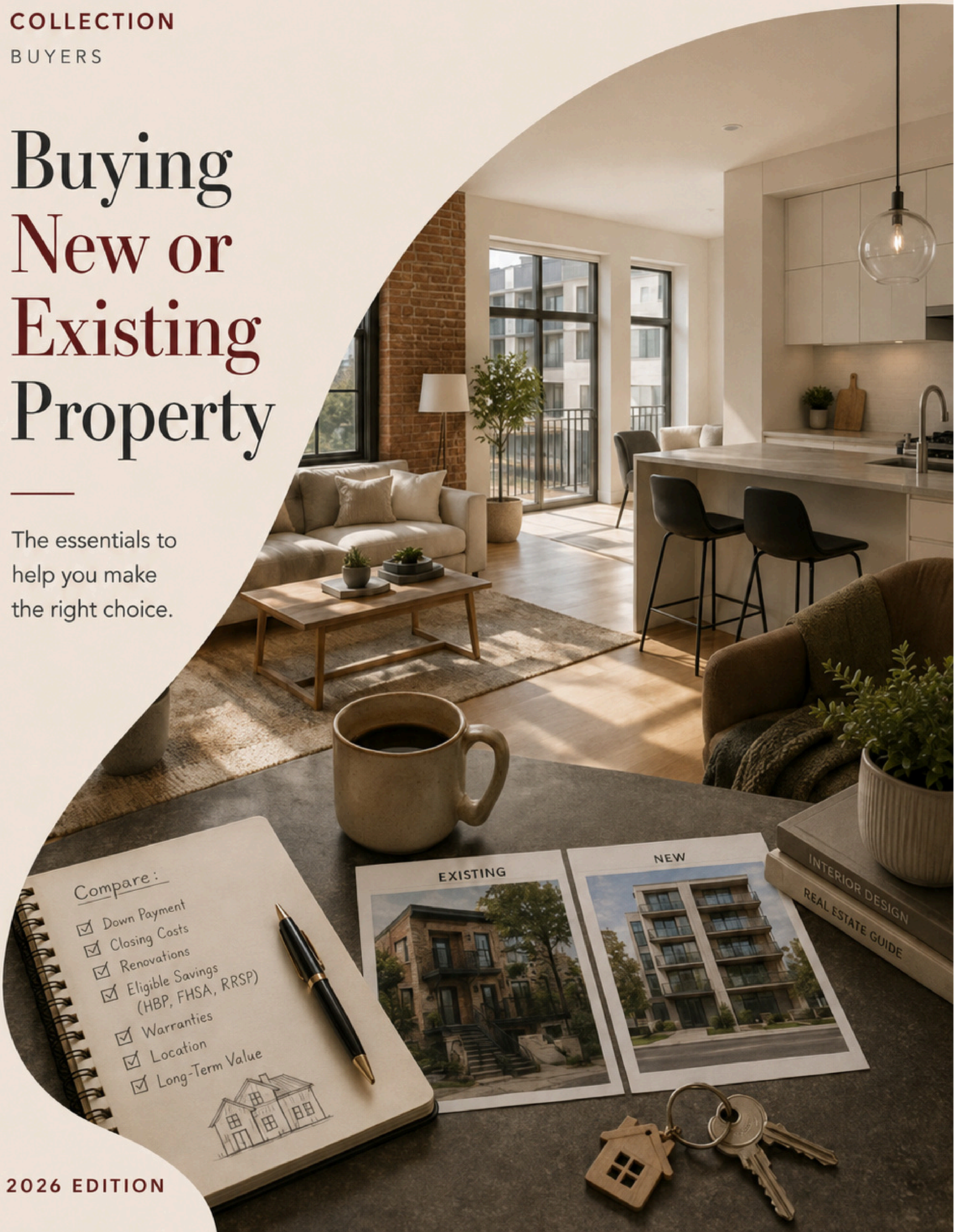
No. 09

COLLECTION

BUYERS

Buying New or Existing Property

The essentials to help you make the right choice.



2026 EDITION

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It presents general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. Every real estate situation is different, and you should consult the appropriate professionals before making a decision about a transaction.

COLLECTION BUYERS · GUIDE NO. 09

Buying New vs. Existing Property

New construction, GCR warranty and resale homes – how to choose well

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New or old? Both have their strengths. The new seduces with the guarantee, energy efficiency and “nothing to renovate”; the old by the charm, the established location and sometimes a better space-price ratio. This guide helps you make an informed choice.

You will understand the residential construction guarantee (GCR), the particularities of purchasing off plan, the deadlines and deposits, and the checks specific to each option.

Each chapter ends with a lined “My Notes” page to compare your options.

New or old: it's not just a question of taste, but of guarantee, budget and tolerance for the unexpected. This guide compares the two honestly - costs, guarantees, purchasing off plan, verifications - for an informed choice.

The benchmarks (2026 edition) are used to understand the logic; validate warranty and financing details with the relevant professionals.

CHAPTER

New vs. old: the real match

> *Weigh the advantages and trade-offs of each option.*

The new

- Advantages: warranty, recent standards, energy efficiency, customization, low initial maintenance.
- Compromise: often more expensive per square foot, developing neighborhoods (services to come), delivery times, taxes applicable to new construction.

The old

- Advantages: established locations, charm, mature trees, sometimes more space for the price.
- Compromise: maintenance and renovations, systems to be modernized, possible surprises (hence the inspection).

Beyond tastes, think about resale and total cost: new is more expensive per square foot but starts without surprises; the old one is often bought less expensively but requires a budget for works. The right choice depends on your tolerance for the unexpected and the time you want to devote to maintenance.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Don't just compare prices: compare the total cost over 5 years, maintenance and energy included. An old "cheaper" one can cost more with a roof and windows to be redone.*

CHAPTER

The residential construction guarantee (GCR)

> *Understand what the new home warranty covers.*

In Quebec, most eligible new homes (including many condos and houses) are covered by a mandatory warranty plan administered by Garantie de construction logement (GCR). It protects the buyer against certain defects and breaches of the manufacturer, according to defined durations and ceilings.

- Protection of deposit and completion of work in the event of default by the builder.
- Coverage for defects and poor workmanship for increasing durations (short deadlines for apparent defects up to several years for major defects).
- Exclusions and conditions exist: read the warranty contract.

2026 edition note: the terms and administrator of the plan may change; confirm the coverage applicable to YOUR purchase with the manufacturer and the notary.

The GCR covers in stages: deposit and completion upon receipt, then hidden defects and major defects over longer periods (generally up to 5 years for major defects). It has limits and exclusions: read the warranty contract and keep your receipt documents.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Ask for proof of warranty registration and read what it covers BEFORE signing. A beautiful new unit without a proper warranty is a risk not to be taken.*

CHAPTER

Buy off plan: deadlines, deposits, choice

> *Master the particularities of purchasing before construction.*

Buying off plan (before or during construction) allows you to personalize and sometimes obtain a better price, but has specific features: payment of installments, delivery times that can slip, and a final product that you don't see until the end.

- Check the protection of your deposits (via the guarantee).
- Clarify what is included vs optional (finishes, appliances).
- Allow for a margin on the delivery date and its impact on your current accommodation.
- Perform a pre-delivery inspection to list deficiencies to be corrected.

Buying off plan carries its own risks: delivery times, choices made early, and possible discrepancy between the rendering and the result. Check the protection of your deposits, late payment penalties and the reputation of the builder. Perform a pre-receipt inspection and note all deficiencies in writing.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *On plan, anything that is not written does not exist. Have each inclusion, finish and deadline specified in writing. The “model kitchen” is not always the one delivered.*

CHAPTER

Check out an old property

> *Reduce the risk on an existing property.*

On the old one, the professional inspection is your best ally. Target the age and condition of major components (roof, windows, foundation, systems) and Quebec points (clay soils, pyrite, French drain, buried tank, vermiculite).

Budget for the renovations to be planned within 5 years and include them in your price decision. An old charm is worth it... when you buy with your eyes open.

On the old one, target the expensive items: roof, foundation, drain, plumbing, electricity, windows. A period charm can hide expensive upgrades. Inspection and, if necessary, targeted expertise transform uncertainty into a clear budget - and negotiation leverage.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *On an old property, ask yourself not "is it beautiful?" » but "what will cost me a lot in the next 5 years?" ". That's buying smart.*

CHAPTER

Anticipate maintenance according to age

> *Budget beyond the purchase price.*

New or old, each property has its own spending profile. The purchase price is just the beginning:

- **New** : little maintenance in the first years, but sometimes finishing costs (development, fencing, earthworks).
- **Former** : charm and an often lower price, but components to watch out for (roof, windows, plumbing, electricity).

Plan a **maintenance funds** Annual: A common rule is to set aside a small percentage of the value each year for contingencies.

Regardless of age, set aside a small percentage of the value each year for maintenance and contingencies. A “cheap” house with a roof at the end of its life can cost more than a well-finished new one. The real price is the purchase price PLUS future maintenance.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Always ask the age of the major components: roof, heating, windows. A “cheap” house with a roof at the end of its life can cost more than a well-finished new one. The real price is price + maintenance.*

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

> *Your next steps, concretely.*

This week

1. List my priorities (guarantee, location, space, budget).
2. Compare the total cost over 5 years of a new option and an old one.

Within 30 days

1. For new: check the warranty and inclusions in writing.
2. For the old: plan for the inspection and a renovation budget.

Then

1. Decide with Emilie the option that is most consistent with my life plan.

According to my choice

1. New/off plan: check the GCR guarantee, deposit protection and reputation of the manufacturer.
2. Former: plan the inspection and a realistic work budget.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- GCR: Residential construction guarantee, guarantee plan for new homes in Quebec.
- Purchase off plan: purchase before or during construction, with installments.
- Pre-delivery inspection: visit to list deficiencies before taking possession.
- Total cost over 5 years: price + maintenance + energy + planned renovations.
- Major defects: serious defects covered for a longer period by the guarantee.

- GCR: residential construction guarantee for eligible new homes.
- Major defect: defect compromising the solidity of the work, covered for a longer period.
- Purchase off plan: purchase before/during construction, based on the plans.
- Pre-receipt: visit before delivery to record deficiencies.
- Maintenance reserve: amount set aside each year for work.

GO FURTHER

Quiz - test yourself

1. A typical advantage of new is:

A) Mature trees

B) Guarantee and energy efficiency

C) A still established neighborhood

D) No lifetime maintenance

2. A typical advantage of the former is:

A) The new warranty

B) An established location and sometimes more space for the price

C) No renovation

D) Guaranteed lower taxes

3. GCR is used to:

A) Set the price

B) Protect the buyer of a new home (deposit, defects)

C) Pay the welcome tax

D) Insure the car

4. Before signing something new, you must:

A) Ignore the warranty

B) Require proof of warranty registration and read coverage

C) Pay cash

D) Check nothing

5. On a plan, a golden rule is:

A) Rely on the spoken word

B) Have inclusions, finishes and deadlines specified in writing

C) Ask nothing

D) Pay everything upfront without protection

6. A pre-delivery inspection serves to:

A) Set the rent

B) List the deficiencies to be corrected before taking possession

C) Choose the color

D) Pay the notary

7. On the former, the best ally is:

A) The photo of the sheet

B) Professional inspection

C) The neighbor's opinion

D) The weather

8. The correct question about the former is:

A) Is it beautiful?

B) What will be expensive in 5 years?

C) What color?

D) Is there a garden?

Answers

1. B - Guarantee and recent standards (chap. 1).

2. B - Established Locations and Charm (Chapter 1).

3. B - This is the guarantee plan for new homes (chap. 2).

4. B - We confirm the coverage before signing (chap. 2).

5. B - What is not written does not exist (chap. 3).

6. B - We note the deficiencies to be corrected (chap. 3).

7. B - It targets the major components and Quebec points (chap. 4).

8. B - We budget for future renovations (chap. 4).

Make informed decisions.
Choose with confidence.
Move forward without regret.

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